

Lessons not learnt: On Trump and the Department of Education

Trump's **move** to **shut** Department of Education **is** irresponsible

A new broom sweeps clean, but reckless change serves little purpose. After targeting health care — pulling the United States out of the World Health Organization and paralysing USAID — U.S. President Donald Trump has turned to another **cornerstone** of the state: education, whose long-term **significance** to any nation **is** **indisputable**. Last week, he signed an executive order to “begin **eliminating**” the federal Department of Education (DoE), **vowing to shut** it **down** “as quickly as possible”. Established in 1979, the DoE **administers** federal student loans for college and university students, and provides targeted support for **disadvantaged** groups, including students from low-income families and those with disabilities. As in India, public K-12 schools in the U.S. are primarily managed at the State level, with only a **fraction** of their funding coming from the federal government. Yet the DoE plays a critical role in ensuring a **baseline** of **equity**. White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt defended the executive order by **citing decades** of “failing test scores” and low student performance, despite over \$3 trillion in federal spending. “What has been the return on that investment for the American taxpayer?” she asked. But demanding a measurable return on investment on public welfare is not just **misguided** — it **borders on malevolence**. It targets the most **vulnerable** students and risks **stripping away** their only path out of **adversity**.

The Department of Education has long **been in the cross hairs** of **Conservatives**; since the Reagan era, **abolishing** it has been a Republican aspiration. But no one has come closer to realising that goal than Mr. Trump. Even before signing this order, the department's workforce had been nearly halved, with **abrupt terminations** issued under the Elon Musk-led Department of Government Efficiency — now a **hallmark** of the new administration's approach. **Critics** have **denounced** the move, arguing that if student outcomes are truly the concern, efforts should first focus on reforming and strengthening the system, and not **dismantling** it. Crucially, the executive order cannot **take full effect** without Congressional approval — and it remains to be seen whether Mr. Trump's **political will** can carry it through. Already, **lawsuits** are being filed in federal courts, challenging the order's **legality**. The **future** of millions of disadvantaged students **hangs in the balance**. It is up to the rest of the U.S. to ensure that a lifeline is not **pulled out**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

Vocabulary

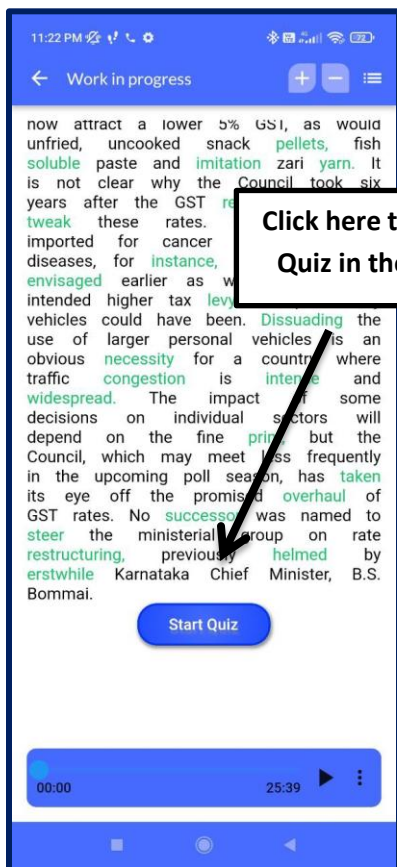
1. **Learn the lesson** (phrase) – Absorb, Grasp, Understand, Realize, Heed सीख लेना
2. **Shut** (verb) – Close, Seal, Lock, Bar, Block बंद करना
3. **A new broom sweeps clean** (phrase) – A new leader or approach brings significant changes नई शुरुआत का प्रभाव
4. **Reckless** (adjective) – Rash, Careless, Impulsive, Hasty, Negligent लापरवाह
5. **Cornerstone** (noun) – Foundation, Basis, Keystone, Bedrock, Pillar आधारशिला
6. **Indisputable** (adjective) – Undeniable, Unquestionable, Irrefutable, Certain, Incontestable निर्विवाद
7. **Eliminate** (verb) – Remove, Eradicate, Abolish, Exterminate, Obliterate खत्म करना
8. **Vow** (verb) – Pledge, Swear, Promise, Commit, Avow प्रतिज्ञा करना
9. **Shut down** (phrasal verb) – Close, Terminate, Cease, Discontinue, Halt बंद कर देना
10. **Administer** (verb) – Manage, Oversee, Direct, Govern, Supervise प्रबंध करना
11. **Disadvantaged** (adjective) – Underprivileged, Deprived, Marginalized, Poor, Needy वंचित
12. **Fraction** (noun) – Portion, Part, Segment, Fragment, Sliver अंश
13. **Baseline** (noun) – Standard, Reference, Guideline, Benchmark, Criterion आधार रेखा
14. **Equity** (noun) – Fairness, Justice, Impartiality, Balance, Equality न्याय
15. **Cite** (verb) – Quote, Reference, Mention, Name, Specify हवाला देना
16. **Decade** (noun) – Period of Ten years, दशक
17. **Misguided** (adjective) – Misled, Wrong, Misinformed, Ill-advised, Foolish गुमराह
18. **Border on** (verb) – to come very close to being something, often a negative
19. **Malevolence** (noun) – Malice, Spite, Hatred, Ill-will, Venom दुर्भावना
20. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – Exposed, Defenseless, Sensitive, Weak, At-risk असुरक्षित
21. **Strip away** (phrasal verb) – Remove, Eliminate, Erode, Deprive, Peel छीन लेना
22. **Adversity** (noun) – Hardship, Misfortune, Difficulty, Trouble, Crisis विपत्ति
23. **Be in the cross hairs** (phrase) – To be targeted for criticism or attack निशाने पर होना

24. **Conservative** (noun) – A member of a U.S. political group (typically Republican) favoring traditional policies रूढ़िवादी (अमेरिकी राजनीति)
25. **Abolish** (verb) – Eliminate, Eradicate, Nullify, Revoke, Annul समाप्त करना
26. **Abrupt** (adjective) – Sudden, Hasty, Unexpected, Sharp, Rude अचानक
27. **Termination** (noun) – End, Conclusion, Cessation, Discontinuation, Closure समाप्ति
28. **Hallmark** (noun) – Trademark, Characteristic, Feature, Stamp, Quality विशेषता
29. **Critics** (noun) – Reviewers, Analysts, Commentators, Evaluators, Judges आलोचक
30. **Denounce** (verb) – Condemn, Criticize, Censure, Blame, Reject निंदा करना
31. **Dismantle** (verb) – Disassemble, Demolish, Deconstruct, Break down, Strip विखंडित करना
32. **Take effect** (phrase) – Implement, Enforce, Activate, Operate, Commence प्रभावी होना
33. **Political will** (noun) – Determination, Resolve, Commitment, Drive, Intent राजनीतिक इच्छाशक्ति
34. **Lawsuit** (noun) – Legal case, Litigation, Court case, Suit, Prosecution मुकदमा
35. **Legality** (noun) – Lawfulness, Validity, Legitimacy, Justice, Authority कानूनी वैधता
36. **Hangs in the balance** (phrase) – To be in an uncertain or undecided state अनिश्चित होना
37. **Pull out** (phrasal verb) – Withdraw, Retreat, Remove, Extract, Quit बाहर निकलना

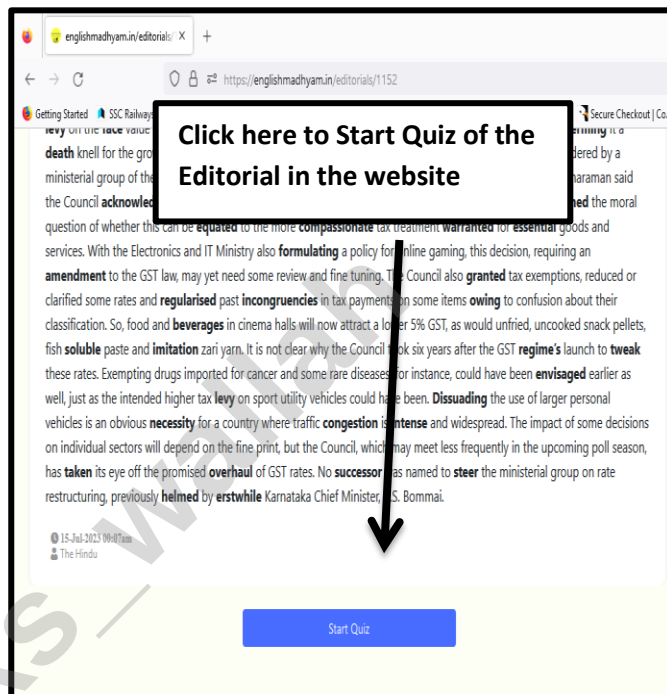
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Trump's executive order** aims to **shut down the U.S. Department of Education (DoE)**, calling it wasteful.
2. The DoE, established in **1979**, manages **federal student loans** and supports **low-income and disabled students**.
3. While **K-12 schools** are mostly state-run, the DoE ensures **baseline equity** in education.
4. The White House justifies the move by citing **poor test scores** and **\$3 trillion in federal spending** with "low returns."
5. Critics argue that **measuring education purely by ROI** is flawed—it harms **vulnerable students** who rely on federal aid.
6. **Conservatives have long opposed the DoE**, with Republicans (since Reagan) seeking its abolition.
7. Trump has **already slashed the DoE's workforce by half** under the **Elon Musk-led "Department of Government Efficiency."**
8. **Abrupt terminations** and aggressive downsizing reflect the administration's **reckless approach to governance**.
9. Critics argue that **reforming (not dismantling) the system** would better address educational shortcomings.
10. The executive order **cannot fully take effect without Congressional approval**, making its future uncertain.
11. **Legal challenges** have been filed in federal courts, questioning the order's **legality and constitutionality**.
12. If implemented, the move could **deprive millions of disadvantaged students** of financial aid and support.
13. The decision follows Trump's **previous attacks on public institutions**, like **exiting the WHO** and **crippling USAID**.
14. The editorial warns against **short-sighted policymaking** that prioritizes ideology over **long-term societal benefits**.
15. The **fate of U.S. education equity** now depends on **Congress, courts, and public resistance** to prevent irreversible damage.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



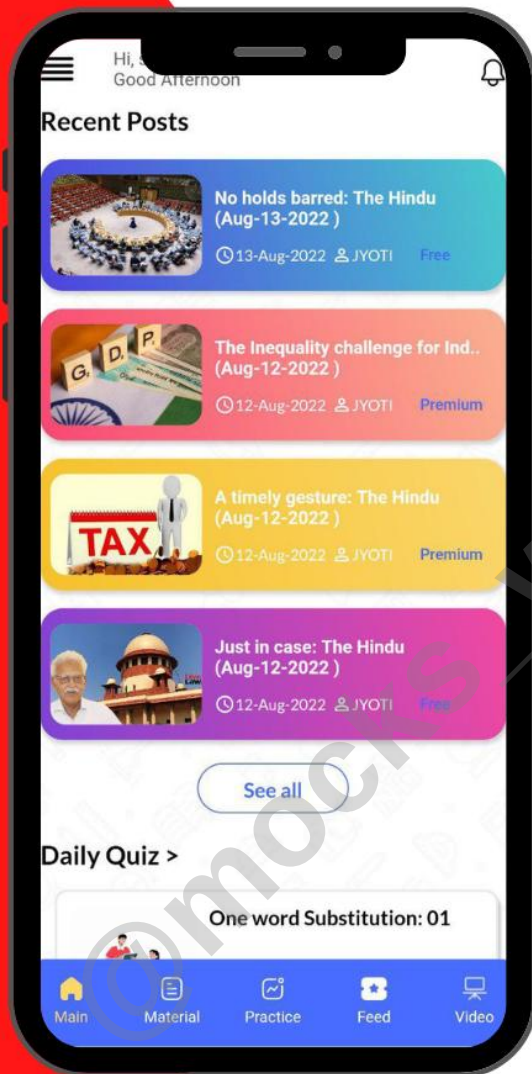
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